

YADADRI TEMPLE

THE GOD OF BIG THINGS

By Amarnath K. Menon

Normally when you think of the kind of conflicts the bifurcation of a state can bring, you think of tangible, material things—say, natural resources or a massive, built-up aggregate of human endeavour like a capital city. No one thinks of cultural heritage and the abstract value this form of capital affords. The 2014 division of erstwhile Andhra Pradesh into an eponymous coastal state and landlocked Telangana was consumed by disputes about Hyderabad. But if the rump state of Andhra Pradesh lost the Pearl of the Deccan, it also retained something else: Tirupati. Losing out on one of the holiest—and richest—shrines of Hinduism has evidently been a matter of resentment for Telangana. Enough to goad Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) into an expansive project to create a counterpart. It has taken Telangana five years and Rs 1,800 crore to open the doors of the refurbished Sri Lakshmi Narasimha Swamy temple at Yadagirigutta, 70 km east of Hyderabad. Heritage that's new? Odd as that may sound, KCR's first prayers at the shrine would have surely involved a fervent hope that this becomes a mega pilgrimage centre rivalling the famous hill shrine that lies 500-plus km to the south.

Playing patrons to big temples has been the historical preserve of kings. And critics are asking if KCR is not using the temple project, funded by public money, to burnish his own image as one with a divine right to rule—especially since talk of the assembly election being advanced has started again, a strategy KCR has not been averse to in the past. That's why the deity's consecration ceremony on March 28, led by the CM himself, was seen as a sign that he is in fact seeking to consecrate himself alongside. It was a strictly official event, attended only by his cabinet colleagues, excluding rival parties, and keeping out even state governor Tamilisai Soundararajan, with whom the CM's relationship is known to be strained.

The mammoth makeover project, launched on October 11, 2016, already contained all the clues needed to see where it was going. Along with Vaishnavite spiritual guru Chinna Jeeyar Swamy, KCR undertook an aerial survey of the area and proposed incorporating eight additional contiguous hillocks, so as to rival Tirumala's seven. He then constituted the Yadagirigutta Temple Development Authority (YTDA), and appointed himself chairman. He even formally shortened the name Yadagirigutta to the handier Yadadri. Before the renovation, the temple complex was limited to 2,500 square yards. The refurbished Yadadri is to be a massive 2,000-acre complex centred around a 17-acre, three-storeyed structure with elaborate sculptures and seven gopurams. The largest of these—the 85-ft high Sapthathala Maharajagopuram, at the temple